

effective remedy for chronic dry and irritable coughs. It combines well with coltsfoot (*Tussilago farfara*, p. 278) as a treatment for asthma and whooping cough. The astringent bark also helps treat indigestion and the symptoms of irritable bowel syndrome, especially when these conditions are of nervous origin.

Caution Wild cherry bark is highly toxic in excessive doses.



Wild cherry bears long spikes of white flowers, followed by fleshy, blue-black fruit.

Psoralea corylifolia (Fabaceae) Bu Gu Zhi

Description Perennial growing to 3 ft (90cm). Has oval leaves, yellow clover-like flowers, and black seed pods containing yellow-black seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation *Bu gu zhi* is native to southern and southeastern Asia and cultivated in China. The fruit is gathered when ripe in autumn.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents The seeds contain a volatile oil, flavonoids, a flavone, and furanocoumarins.

History & Folklore In the Chinese tradition, *bu gu zhi* has long been considered a tonic remedy. It was first documented in *Grandfather Lei's Discussion of Herb Preparations*, which was written in about 490 CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Valued as a *yang* tonic, *bu gu zhi* is taken in China to treat impotence and premature ejaculation and to improve vitality. The seeds are also used to counter debility and other problems reflecting "kidney *yang* deficiency," such as lower back pain, frequent urination, incontinence, and bed-wetting. *Bu gu zhi* is used externally to treat skin conditions such as psoriasis,

alopecia (loss of hair), and vitiligo (loss of skin pigmentation). In Vietnam, a tincture of the seeds is used in the treatment of rheumatism.

Research Studies in China indicate that this herb is of value in the treatment of skin disorders, including vitiligo.

Caution Applied externally, this herb may sensitize the skin, resulting in an allergic reaction to sunlight.

Pterocarpus marsupium (Fabaceae) Kino

Description Handsome deciduous tree growing to 52 ft (16 m). Has leaves with 5–7 oval leathery leaflets, and numerous small yellow or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Sri Lanka, India, Malaysia and the Philippines, kino grows in tropical rainforests. The tree is cultivated for its timber and for the sap ("kino") that exudes from cuts made in the trunk. The sap is collected year round.

Part Used Sap.

Constituents Kino contains tannins, flavonoids, and marsupin.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Kino is a strongly astringent herb that tightens the mucous membranes of the gastrointestinal tract. Kino relieves chronic diarrhea and the irritation caused by intestinal infection and colitis. Though its taste is unpleasant, this herb makes a good mouthwash and gargle. It is widely used in Asia as a douche for excessive vaginal discharge.

Research Clinical trials have found that the herb is therapeutically useful in treating the early stages of non-insulin-dependent diabetes.

Ptychopetalum olacoides syn. *P. uncinatum* (Oleaceae) Muira Puama

Description Tree growing to 49 ft (15 m) with a gray trunk, dark brown leaves, white flowers, and orange-yellow fruits.

Habitat & Cultivation Muira puama is native to Brazilian rainforests, especially the Rio Negro and Amazonas regions.

Part Used Root, bark, wood.

Constituents Muira puama contains esters and plant sterols.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Muira puama has long been used in Amazonian medicine as a tonic and aphrodisiac. Considered useful as an aid for impotence, it is thought to help with both physical and psychological aspects of the problem.

It is also used to treat or prevent baldness.

The bark is strongly astringent and is employed as a gargle for sore throats and taken in the form of an infusion in order to treat diarrhea and dysentery.

Related Species *Liriodendron ovata*, another Brazilian tree, is also known as muira puama, but has quite distinct chemical constituents.

Pueraria lobata syn. *P. thunbergiana* (Fabaceae) Kudzu, Ge Gen (Chinese)

Description Deciduous climber growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has leaves with 3 broadly oval leaflets, curling tendrils, and spikes of pea-type purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, Japan, and eastern Asia, kudzu is naturalized in the U.S. It is cultivated in the central and eastern provinces of China. The root is unearthed in spring or autumn.



Kudzu is used in China to treat alcoholism and is an ingredient in a remedy for hangovers.

Parts Used Root, flower.

Constituents Kudzu contains triterpenoid saponins, isoflavones, and phytosterols. The isoflavones are estrogenic.

History & Folklore From the 6th century BCE onward, Chinese herbalists have considered kudzu to be a remedy for muscular pain and a treatment for measles. Zhang Zhongjing (150–c. 219 CE) recommended kudzu if the patient "has a stiff back and muscles, does not breathe easily, and is susceptible to wind."

Medicinal Actions & Uses In China, kudzu is frequently used as a remedy for measles, often in combination with *sheng ma* (*Cimicifuga foetida*).